A zipper clicks together.

01 What changes right where the slider sits?



A close imagined view. The zipper is enlarged to help us see.

Look closer. Below the slider are two separate rows. Above it is one joined row.

A little explanation. The slider does not glue the sides. It guides matching zipper teeth into an interlocking pattern.

Try this. Trace each open row toward the slider, then follow the single closed row away from it.

02 Why are zipper teeth shaped with bumps and pockets?



Zipper elements are enlarged and simplified so their nesting shapes are clear.

Look closer. A bump on one side settles into a pocket on the other side.

A little explanation. Alternating teeth nest across the gap. Their shapes help the two rows hold together.

Try this. Point to one left tooth, then the right tooth that fits beside it.

03 What path is hiding inside the slider?



A cutaway explanation of the hidden channel, enlarged and simplified.

Look closer. Two wide channels curve toward one narrow opening, like the arms of a Y.

A little explanation. The slider's Y-shaped channel bends both rows inward in the right order.

Try this. Draw a Y in the air. Bring two fingertips down its arms and out together.

04 How can the same slider open the zipper again?



The same hidden path can join the teeth or guide them apart.

Look closer. Moving the other way sends the joined row toward the fork in the channel.

A little explanation. The center wedge guides the interlocked teeth apart and sends each row out a different side.

Try this. Trace the joined row toward the fork, then split your fingers along two paths.